# REIGNING DIVA

## DEEPIKA PADUKONE, 35

*Actor*

In the late '80s, Sridevi reigned supreme; the noughties were all about Madhuri. 2010s have seen both the emergence—and the dominance—of Deepika Padukone. Given her upcoming line-up of films that feature co-stars like Shah Rukh Khan, Amitabh Bachchan, Hrithik Roshan and Prabhas, Deepika is determined she won't let the ongoing decade slip by.

An array of films showcase how much she has evolved as an actor. She can be a graceful diva lighting up the screen (the three collaborations with Sanjay Leela Bhansali), the charming mainstream heroine (*Chennai Express*, *Yeh Jawaani Hai Deewani*), the assured actor (*Cocktail*, *Piku*, *Tamasha*) and, more recently, a smart producer (*Chhapaak*, '83). That her films fare well at the box office is an added incentive, making her one of the highest-paid and sought-after actresses in the industry. In a highly competitive world where actresses are made to settle for less, be it screen time or meaningful parts in big-budget spectacles, Deepika has ensured she works on her own terms.

The ability to wield such influence comes from learning from one's mistakes. "I fell into that trap of what a heroine is expected to do and what she should look like," she told India Today Woman a few years back. "It has been a journey of self-discovery." History has time and again shown that careers of the biggest leading ladies come with a shelf life. Wiser and creatively hungrier, Deepika intends to be an exception. ■

*–Suhani Singh*

**ANGEL INVESTOR** Padukone has invested in companies such as Epigamia, Furlenco, Purpple and space start-up Bellatrix Aerospace